Great Expectations: Context

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Nick Redgrove
Reviewed by: Kate Lee
Updated on 30 June 2025

Great Expectations historical and social context

Social class

- The novel was written in 1860–1 but is set earlier in the century, mostly during the Regency and later Georgian period
- This was a time of rapid political, industrial and social change, with four monarchs reigning in England within a very short period of time:
  - Following King George III's bout of madness, the Prince Regent (his son) was given power in 1810 and later became King George IV (1820–30)
  - King William succeeded him between 1830–7 when Queen Victoria was crowned as queen
- The majority of the events in Great Expectations take place before 1830, and even though there were important innovations during the novel's time period, they are not explored in the narrative itself:
  - Pip's narrative takes place between Christmas Eve in 1812 and sometime around the winter of 1840
- During this period, social class could be easily distinguished by a person's manner of speaking and their appearance
- Your social class was not solely determined by noble lineage or your relationship with the aristocracy:
  - Instead, being accepted by the ruling class often required simply demonstrating that your wealth had been acquired in a gentlemanly manner
- This was a period when the upper classes displayed a snobbish contempt and disdain for those beneath them:
  - They believed that by imposing strict class barriers, they could prevent the **encroachment** of the rapidly urbanising lower classes

How this links to Great Expectations	
Social shifts	Although Georgian and Victorian society is often viewed as a rigidly **stratified** one with firmly established class distinctions, Dickens reveals a contrasting narrative.

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

	or vice versa. For example, Miss Havisham's wealth has been earned rather than inherited but she has a powerful status in the novel.
Class consciousness	When Estella first meets Pip in the novel, she is quick to criticise him for using the term "Jacks" instead of "knaves". Pip is self-conscious about his clothing while at Satis House and he acknowledges that Joe looks presentable in his work clothes but appears dishevelled in his "best" outfit. As Pip becomes more affluent, he adopts a completely different persona and learns refined mannerisms including speech, attire, and dining etiquette in order to be recognised as an upper-class gentleman. Estella highlights the inadequacy of the early 19th-century belief that possessing "good breeding" is a necessary trait of a true upper-class gentleman or lady. The fact that Estella is Miss Havisham's ward is well-established, but her adoption as a child obscures any speculation about her former class origins. Estella embodies a lady-like demeanour, exhibiting impressive speech and dress that match her fine appearance. In certain aspects, Joe can be viewed as defying class stereotypes, but his use of language also defines his class status defines him. This aligns with the contemporary Victorian idea that social class was predetermined by **divine order** and should not be challenged.

Help me understand

Integrity and reputation

- People in the 19th century were eager to ensure that they were adhering to the conventions of behaviour and etiquette, outlined in popular published guides about proper behaviour and conduct
- The concept of a gentleman or lady in the 19th century referred to individuals who displayed integrity and conducted themselves with grace in their respective social roles:
    - However, it was evident that social status and morality were not always linked
- Respectability was a key aspect of Victorian society and there were strict social codes regarding behaviour and moral and social conventions were highly valued
- The social standards of the time expected gentlemen and bachelors to act in a dignified and respectable manner, with the highest standards of behaviour

aristocracy:
    - This led to a debate about what it meant to be a 'gentleman' and whether their qualities could be acquired or were merely based upon one's birth right:
        - Some argued that a gentleman was someone who behaved with respect and civility, regardless of his social class
        - Others argued a gentleman could only be someone of a particular social standing who had certain privileges and obligations

How this links to Great Expectations	
Integrity and reputation	Dickens was interested in the numerous ways that people exhibited and asserted their social identity, class and goals, including subtle differences in dress, speech, and conduct. In Great Expectations, he depicts characters on the fringes of social classes, including those who struggle to maintain their appearance of respectability as well as those who unexpectedly experience social mobility within the volatile Victorian economy. For example, despite his villainous nature, Compeyson appears like a gentleman due to his clothing and education, while Magwitch's ragged appearance hinders his chances of receiving fair treatment under the law.

Ambition and self-improvement

- Great Expectations takes place during the Industrial Revolution and it was a time characterised by significant advancements in technology:
    - This opened up numerous financial possibilities for individuals from lower economic backgrounds and provided opportunities for individuals to achieve immense wealth, despite their humble backgrounds
- During the 1830s, there was an increase in social and political unrest:
    - The first Reform Bill in 1832 signalled the beginning of more progressive social policies, as middle class men were given the right to vote
- In 1837, Queen Victoria was crowned, ushering in an era of Victorian values and ideals:
    - Unlike the previous era, when the aristocratic class dominated, this period saw a new shift towards increasing social mobility

How this links to Great Expectations	
Social mobility	By the time Pip returns in 1840, England had undergone a significant transformation and was now highly industrialised, socially progressive and deeply influenced by the new Victorian values. Dickens depicts this new world in the novel as it follows Pip's advancement through

	social mobility among those like Pip, and he depicts a society that is constantly evolving, where wealth can be acquired and lost in an instant.

Great Expectations literary context

Bildungsroman and Gothic genres

- During the Victorian era, the **Bildungsroman** genre emerged as one of the most popular literary types of fiction: it translates as a "novel of education"
  - Like Great Expectations, these novels generally portrayed the protagonist's psychological and moral growth from their youth into adulthood
- The conventional structure of a Bildungsroman involved the following:
  - **Loss:** The protagonist experiences a profound emotional loss at the beginning of the story, typically during their childhood or adolescent years
  - **Journey:** Motivated by their personal tragedy, the protagonist embarks on a journey, either physical or metaphorical, to gain a better understanding of the world
  - **Conflict and personal growth:** The protagonist's journey entails mistakes and often clashes with societal norms, although as the narrative progresses, the protagonist gradually embraces the values of society
  - **Maturity:** By the conclusion of the novel, the protagonist undergoes significant personal development, exhibiting a positive transformation as they reach maturity
- The **Gothic** genre also became popular in the late 18th and early 19th centuries:
  - Dickens made use of gothic elements extensively in Great Expectations

How this links to Great Expectations	
Bildungsroman and Gothic genres	Great Expectations is written in the form of a Bildungsroman, depicting the development and maturity of Pip as a character. The novel also employs gothic features and in many ways, Magwitch could be viewed as an **archetypal** gothic character. He is presented initially as a monster and as grotesque. Miss Havisham is also depicted through Gothic conventions — isolated,

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty
- Quizzes or homework in minutes

Try Test Builder

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Previous Next

Course Study tools All topics

Resources

Learning Hub
Scholarship
Join
Past Papers
Solution Banks
Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview
Brand ambassador
Profile
Subscription
Settings
Log out

Company

About us
Exam Specificity
Content Quality
Promotions
Jobs

Subjects

Biology
Chemistry
Physics
Maths
Geography

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.
Neither IBO nor College Board were involved in the production of, and do not endorse, the resources created by Save My Exams.